HEIRSTONE CONSULTING

UNIVERSITIES AND STUDENT HOUSING IN AFRICA

The bed behind the seat

Africa's 18 to 24 year-olds, the universities competing to teach them and the economics of the student bed, from Cairo and Algiers to Lagos, Nairobi and Pretoria



THE REPORT IN SIX NUMBERS

29.8m — more people aged 18 to 24 in the 15 countries of this report in 2035 than in 2025 (126.4m to 156.2m), on World Bank projections

2.8m — extra university seats needed by 2035 to hold today's enrolment ratios in the 12 countries with current UNESCO data

125,128 — international students in Egypt in 2024, up 79% in two years, against 68,024 Egyptians studying abroad in 2023

182 — private universities in Nigeria in 2026, up from 79 in 2019 and 55.5% of all its universities

44.5 — student beds per 100 university students in Kenya on the listed operator Acorn's estimates, the only market in this report where we could compute the ratio

US$110 — monthly rent for an affordable Nairobi student bed, about 87 to 90% of Kenya's monthly minimum wage

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report covers 15 countries: Egypt, Morocco, Tunisia and Algeria in North Africa; Nigeria, Ghana, Côte d'Ivoire, Senegal and Cameroon in West and Central Africa; Kenya, Ethiopia, Uganda, Tanzania and Rwanda in East Africa; and South Africa. It draws on public sources current in 2026: UNESCO Institute for Statistics data (February 2026 release), the World Bank's population projections (July 2026 update), national regulators, university and operator websites, and the 2025 annual reports of Kenya's two listed student-housing REITs.

Where we combine published figures to produce a new one, such as seats needed by 2035, beds per student or rent as a share of the minimum wage, the result is labelled Heirstone analysis and its inputs are shown. Local-currency amounts are converted to US dollars at rates of 2026.

WHAT WE FOUND

Africa is adding university places faster than beds. Where data exists, the beds that fill are near a campus and most new ones rent below the minimum wage.

The 15 countries in this report will have 29.8 million more people aged 18 to 24 in 2035 than in 2025. Governments and private universities are adding places to seat them. Far less is being built, or even counted, to house them. Where returns can be checked, in Nairobi, the student housing that performs is close to campus and priced for what students or their funders can pay.

1 **Keeping pace needs 2.8 million seats.**

In the 12 countries with current UNESCO data, holding today's gross enrolment ratios to 2035 needs about 2.8 million extra university seats, two thirds of them in Egypt and Algeria. Holding every ratio and lifting those below 20% to that floor needs about 5.4 million. With Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda added on estimated bases, reaching 20% everywhere needs about 11.5 million.

2 **Demand is leaking abroad, and part of it can be won back.**

Nigeria had 146,286 students abroad in 2023, more than double 2019. Students abroad equal 9.6% of domestic enrolment in Tunisia, 8.1% in Cameroon and 6.8% in Senegal. Egypt has moved the other way: it hosted 125,128 international students in 2024 against 68,024 Egyptians studying abroad.

3 **Licences are running ahead of housing.**

Nigeria's private universities rose from 79 in 2019 to 182 in 2026, and Egypt's New Administrative Capital hosts four branch-campus hubs, the largest cluster we found in Africa. Kenya is the only market where we could compute beds per student (44.5 per 100), and a Durban campus planned for 8,000 students includes 500 beds.

4 **Occupancy follows access to campus.**

Acorn's stabilised Nairobi portfolio averaged 81% occupancy in 2025: 94% in four core assets and 62% in three pilot assets. Its emptiest block (48%) sits just beyond 2.5 km from the main institutions, according to Acorn; the two near USIU-Africa ran at 94 and 95%.

5 **The rent has to fit whoever pays it.**

An affordable Nairobi bed costs about US$110 a month, 87 to 90% of Kenya's monthly minimum wage, and three in four beds Acorn's development REIT has opened are in that tier. A Gauteng sharing bed costs 111% of South Africa's minimum wage. On-campus rooms at AUC and Ashesi, both top-of-market, cost about 1.9 and 4.2 times the local minimum wage.

WHAT IT MEANS

Ministries and regulators should license beds alongside seats and publish what exists: residence capacity, accredited private beds and rents.

Universities should secure a housing partner before the intake, and offer land, referrals or a head lease in return.

Investors and lenders should underwrite the campus next door and the rent-to-wage ratio, and treat national bed-deficit estimates as background.

15

countries in the Heirstone Student City Benchmark, from Algiers to Pretoria

6

tests in the Heirstone Student Bed Test, each drawn from published operating data

CHAPTER 1



01

2.8 million seats to keep pace

A gross enrolment ratio is a share of a moving population. When the age group grows by a quarter, holding the ratio means building a quarter more university.

The 15 countries in this report had about 126.4 million people aged 18 to 24 in 2025. On the World Bank's population projections, updated in July 2026, they will have 156.2 million in 2035, an increase of 29.8 million, or 24%. In 13 of the 15 the cohort grows by more than 10%. Only Morocco and South Africa grow more slowly, by about 7% each.

North Africa's four countries add 6.7 million young people, a rise of 28%, led by Algeria (+51%) and Egypt (+28%). The eleven Sub-Saharan countries add 23.0 million, 22% more, and Nigeria alone adds 9.6 million.

Participation varies far more than growth. Algeria (54%), Morocco (48%), Tunisia (38%) and Egypt (38%) already have mass higher education. Nine of the 15 countries have gross enrolment ratios below 20%, and Tanzania, Uganda and Ethiopia are below 6% on their latest figures.

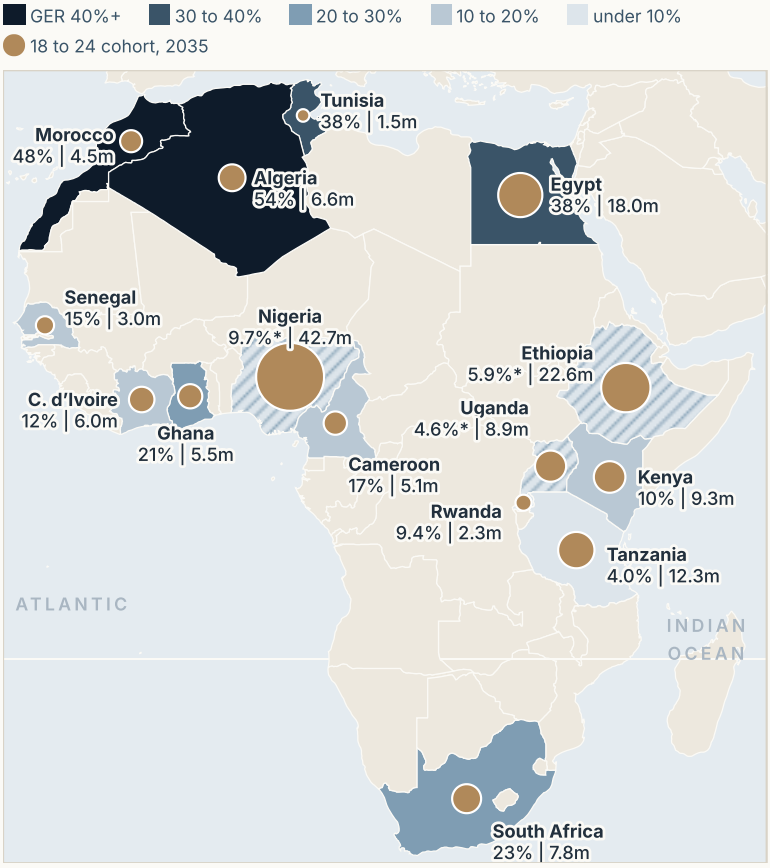
WHO REACHES UNIVERSITY AGE

Nigeria adds the most young people. Algeria and Côte d'Ivoire add them fastest.

EXHIBIT 1

Mass participation in the north, elite participation in the south

Tertiary gross enrolment ratio, latest year (shading); population aged 18 to 24 in 2035 (circles)

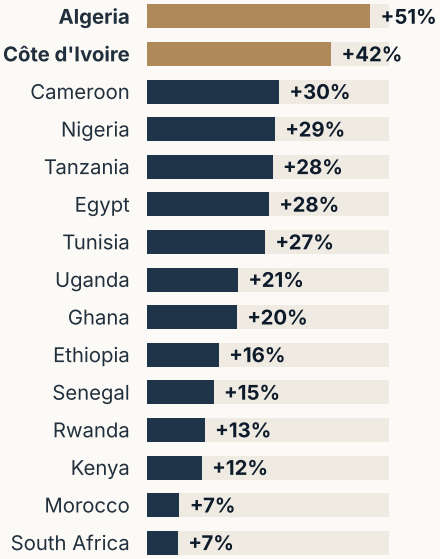


Source: UNESCO Institute for Statistics, GER.5T8 (Feb 2026 release); World Bank WDI SE.TER.ENRR; World Bank Population Estimates and Projections (source 40, Jul 2026). *Hatched: latest ratio is 2011 (Nigeria) or 2014 (Ethiopia, Uganda). Circles at approximate country centres. Boundaries: Natural Earth.

EXHIBIT 2

13 of the 15 cohorts grow by more than 10% to 2035

Change in population aged 18 to 24, 2025 to 2035



Source: World Bank Population Estimates and Projections (source 40, Jul 2026). Ages 18, 19 and 20 to 24 summed, both sexes. **Heirstone analysis.**

Exhibit 1 shows two Africas. In the north, participation is already mass. South of the Sahara only South Africa (23.5%) and Ghana (21.3%) exceed 20%, and the largest cohorts sit in the systems with the lowest participation.

Nigeria's 18 to 24 cohort reaches 42.7 million in 2035, more than the four North African countries combined (30.6 million). Ethiopia reaches 22.6 million and Egypt 18.0 million. In relative terms Algeria grows fastest, by 51%, followed by Côte d'Ivoire at 42%, the fastest rate south of the Sahara in this report.

The figures are population projections from the World Bank's Population Estimates and Projections database, which we use because it is openly accessible and consistent across the 15 countries. How many of these young people enrol depends on places, fees and policy, and the projections should be read alongside the UN's World Population Prospects before any investment decision.

> *In 2035 Nigeria alone will have 42.7 million people of university age, 12 million more than Egypt, Algeria, Morocco and Tunisia combined.*

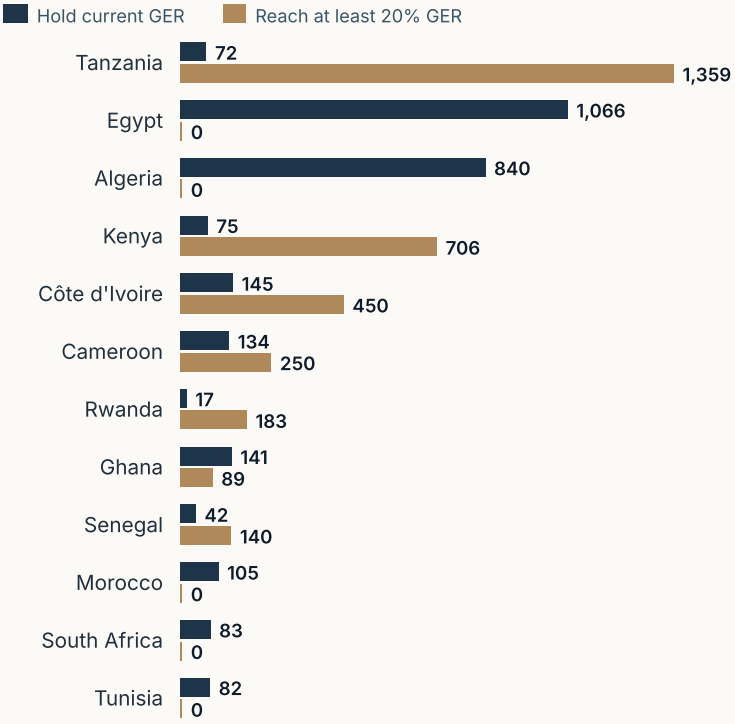
THE SEAT REQUIREMENT

Holding today's ratios needs about 2.8 million seats by 2035, two thirds of them in Egypt and Algeria

EXHIBIT 3

Egypt and Algeria need the most seats to keep pace with their growing cohorts; Tanzania and Kenya the most to reach 20%

Additional tertiary seats needed by 2035, thousands, 12 countries with current UNESCO data

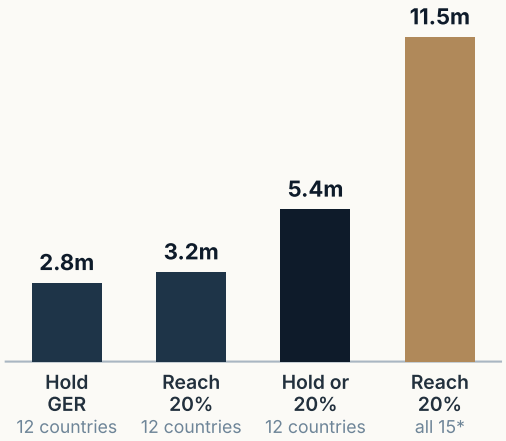


Source: UNESCO UIS (GER.5T8, 25053; Feb 2026); World Bank Population Estimates and Projections (source 40, Jul 2026). **Heirstone analysis:** school-age population implied as enrolment divided by GER, grown with the 18 to 24 cohort 2025 to 2035; seats needed = target minus latest enrolment, floored at zero.

EXHIBIT 4

Depending on the target, the requirement runs from 2.8 to 11.5 million seats

Additional tertiary seats needed by 2035, millions



Source: As Exhibit 3. "Hold or 20%" takes the larger of the two for each country. *Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda estimated from their last UNESCO enrolment (2011, 2014) and five sevenths of the 18 to 24 cohort. **Heirstone analysis.**

4.6m

seats Nigeria would need to reach 20% on our estimate; 3.9m using the 2019 NUC count as its base

2.6m

seats for Ethiopia, and 1.1m for Uganda, on the same estimated basis

Keeping pace is the larger task in North Africa. Egypt needs about 1.07 million more seats and Algeria about 840,000, together 68% of the 2.8 million required across the 12 countries with current data. Egypt is already moving faster: enrolment rose by about 394,000, or 11%, in two years to 2025, to 3.87 million, holding the ratio at 38% while the age group grew almost as fast. On our projection, holding it to 2035 needs about 107,000 more seats a year, against a recent average of about 197,000.

South of the Sahara the issue is the floor. Lifting Tanzania to 20% needs about 1.36 million seats and Kenya about 706,000. Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda have no UNESCO enrolment data since 2011 or 2014, so we estimate them from their last published enrolment and five sevenths of the cohort, the share that matches the five-year age band UNESCO uses. On that basis the three would need about 8.3 million seats to reach 20%, taking the 15-country total to 11.5 million. The estimate overstates the gap to the extent that enrolment has grown since. Using the National Universities Commission's 2019 count of 2.16 million university students as Nigeria's base cuts its figure to 3.9 million and the total to about 10.9 million.

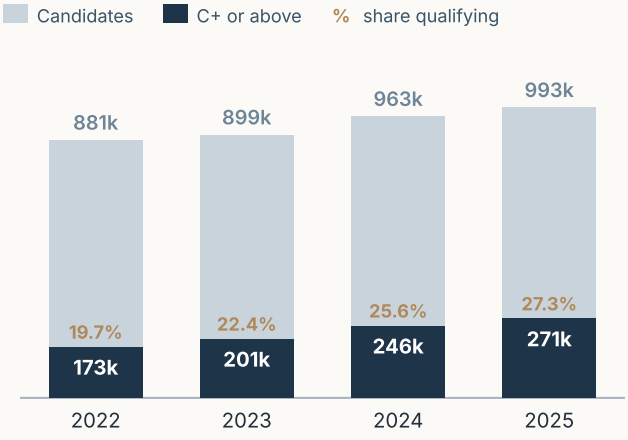
QUEUES AND BLIND SPOTS

Kenya's qualified school leavers rose 56% in three years. Nigeria has not reported a comparable enrolment ratio since 2011.

EXHIBIT 5

Kenya's university qualifiers grew four times as fast as its exam candidates

KCSE candidates and candidates scoring C+ or above (the university entry grade), 2022 to 2025

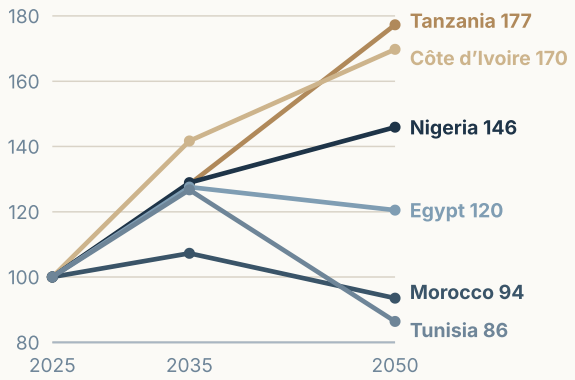


Source: Kenya Ministry of Education KCSE results, as reported by Citizen Digital (2023, 2024, 2026). Shares are **Heirstone analysis**.

EXHIBIT 6

After 2035 growth shifts south: Tanzania's cohort rises 77% by 2050, Tunisia's falls 14%

Population aged 18 to 24, index 2025 = 100



Source: World Bank Population Estimates and Projections (source 40, Jul 2026). **Heirstone analysis.**

Kenya shows what a queue looks like. In 2025, 993,226 candidates sat the KCSE secondary-leaving examination and 270,715 scored C+ or better, the grade that qualifies for university. Three years earlier the figures were 881,416 and 173,345, so the share qualifying rose from 19.7% to 27.3%. One year's qualifiers now equal 44% of Kenya's total tertiary enrolment (611,146 in 2024) and almost the whole national stock of student beds, which Acorn estimates at about 280,000.

Nigeria is the blind spot. UNESCO's latest tertiary enrolment ratio for the country is 9.7%, for 2011. The National Universities Commission counted 2,159,461 students in Nigerian universities in 2019. About 2.24 million candidates registered for the 2026 university matriculation examination, as reported by Channels Television, and JAMB's minimum score for university admission is 150. A Nigerian investment case has to be rebuilt from these national sources.

Beyond 2035 the picture changes again. By 2050 the cohort is 77% larger than in 2025 in Tanzania, 70% in Côte d'Ivoire and 66% in Cameroon, while it is 6.5% smaller in Morocco and 14% smaller in Tunisia.

27.3%

of Kenyan candidates qualified for university in 2025, up from 19.7% in 2022

9.7%

Nigeria's latest UNESCO tertiary enrolment ratio, for 2011

−32%

fall in Tunisia's 18 to 24 cohort between 2035 and 2050

CHAPTER 2

02

The students who leave, and the campuses chasing them

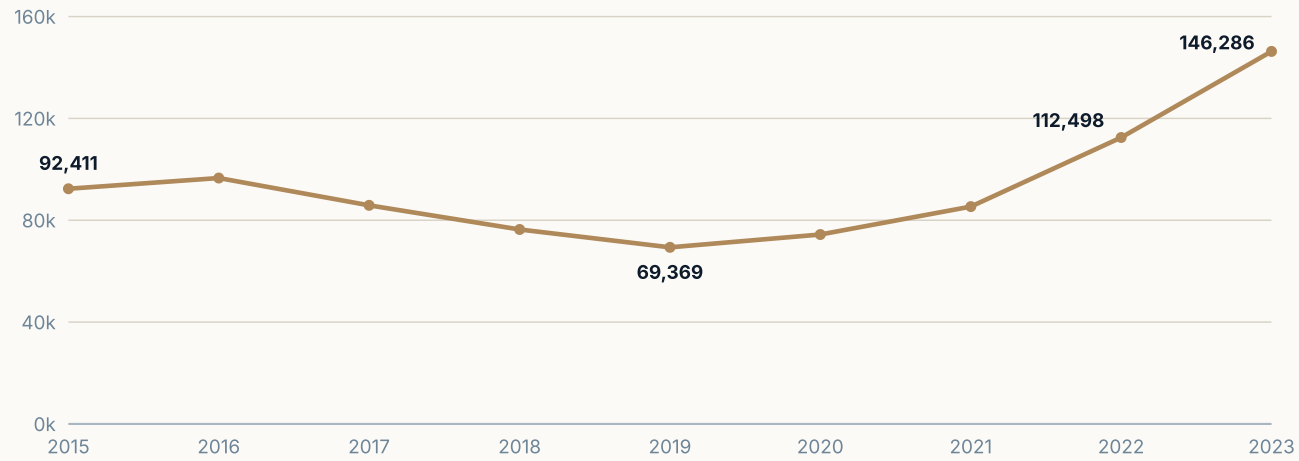
Every system in this report sends students abroad. A student who leaves has usually met the entry requirements and found the money for fees and living costs, often in foreign currency.

For a ministry that is demand lost to another country. For a university or developer at home it is a market that has already shown it will pay. Private universities and international branch campuses are now competing for it, in Lagos and Abuja, in Egypt's new capital, in Kigali and in the listed education groups of South Africa.

EXHIBIT 7

Nigerian students abroad more than doubled between 2019 and 2023

Nigerian tertiary students enrolled abroad, UNESCO estimate, 2015 to 2023



Source: UNESCO Institute for Statistics, OE.5T8.40510, outbound internationally mobile tertiary students (Feb 2026 release).

UNESCO counted 146,286 Nigerian tertiary students abroad in 2023, up 30% in a single year and 111% on the 2019 trough of 69,369. The outbound count kept rising while Nigeria published no internationally comparable enrolment figure. The flow is about one sixth of India's (833,835) and equal to 61% of all the international students the UAE hosted in 2024 (238,986).

Numbers abroad have risen almost everywhere else too. Between 2015 and 2023 Ghanaians abroad rose 78% to 23,842, Kenyans from 13,805 to 23,211, Ivorians from 11,579 to 18,675 and Cameroonians from 25,876 to 33,755. East Africa's flows are smaller: 11,148 Ethiopians, 7,877 Tanzanians, 7,253 Rwandans and 7,108 Ugandans. Beyond the benchmark, the Democratic Republic of Congo sent 20,127 students abroad in 2023.

61%

Nigeria's students abroad as a share of all international students in the UAE. **Heirstone analysis**

+30%

rise in Nigerians studying abroad in a single year, 2022 to 2023

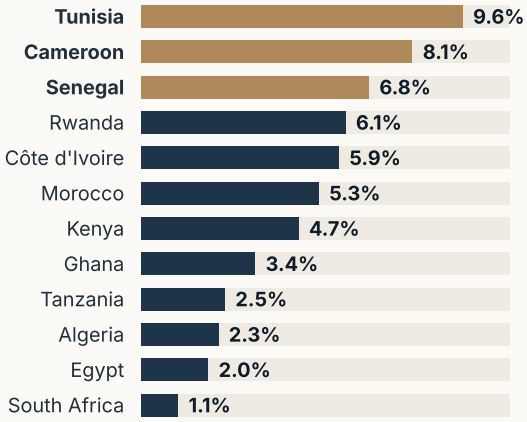
WHO LEAVES, WHO ARRIVES

Tunisia, Cameroon and Senegal send abroad the largest shares of their students. Egypt now takes in nearly two for every one it sends.

EXHIBIT 8

Tunisia sends abroad the equivalent of almost a tenth of its students

Tertiary students abroad as % of domestic tertiary enrolment, 2023

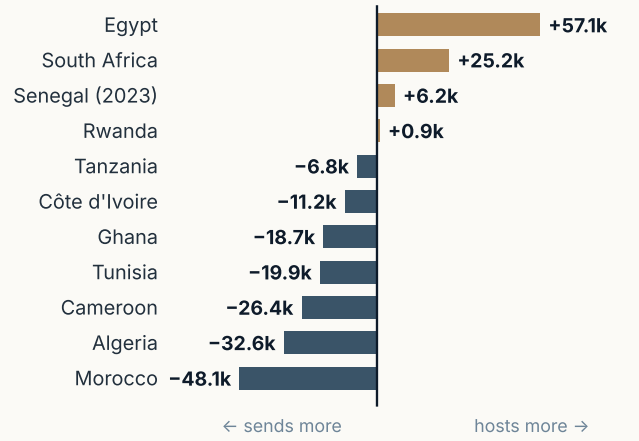


Source: UNESCO UIS, OE.5T8.40510 and 25053 (Feb 2026). **Heirstone analysis.** Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda excluded: no current enrolment data.

EXHIBIT 9

Four systems take in more students than they send

International students hosted minus own students abroad, thousands, latest year



Source: UNESCO UIS, 26637 (inbound, 2023 or 2024) and OE.5T8.40510 (outbound, 2023). Senegal uses 2023 inbound (25,658); UIS reports 83,758 for 2024, which looks like a reporting break. Inbound not reported for Nigeria, Kenya, Ethiopia, Uganda. **Heirstone analysis.**

Francophone and Maghreb systems lose the largest shares. Tunisia's 29,353 students abroad equal 9.6% of its domestic enrolment, Cameroon's 33,755 equal 8.1% and Senegal's 19,498 equal 6.8%. Morocco sent 75,186 in 2023, 68% more than in 2015, while hosting 27,064. Algeria's outbound number nearly doubled over the same period, to 38,304.

Egypt has moved the other way. It hosted 125,128 international students in 2024, 79% more than in 2022, against 68,024 Egyptians abroad in 2023, about 1.8 arrivals for every departure. South Africa hosts 2.9 for every student it sends. Rwanda (8,122 in, 7,253 out) and, on 2023 figures, Senegal also take in more than they send, which makes them destinations as well as sources.

Gulf universities compete for these students too. The UAE hosted 238,986 international tertiary students in 2024 and Saudi Arabia 114,886. For a family in Lagos, Abidjan or Douala, a campus in Cairo, Dubai or the home city is now a realistic alternative, and each comes with a different housing offer and price.

125,128

international students in Egypt in 2024, up 79% in two years

75,186

Moroccan students abroad in 2023, 68% more than in 2015

238,986

international students in the UAE in 2024; Saudi Arabia hosted 114,886

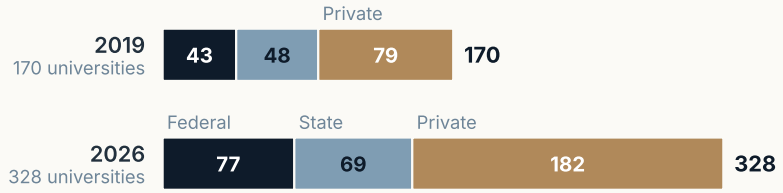
THE PRIVATE RESPONSE

Private institutions account for 103 of the 158 universities Nigeria added between 2019 and 2026

EXHIBIT 10

Nigeria's private universities more than doubled in seven years

Universities by ownership, 2019 and 2026



Source: National Universities Commission, 2019 Nigerian University System Statistical Digest (Table 1.1.1); NUC homepage statistics and private universities list (2026). **Heirstone analysis.**

55.5%

private share of Nigeria's 328 universities in 2026, against 46.5% in 2019

6.25

beds per 100 students planned at ADvTECH's Durban campus (500 beds, 8,000 students). **Heirstone analysis**

Licensing new institutions has become a main route to added capacity. Nigeria had 170 universities in 2019, 79 of them private. By 2026 the National Universities Commission listed 328: 77 federal, 69 state and 182 private, a large batch of them licensed in 2026. Private institutions now make up 55.5% of the total.

Other regulators show the same shift. Ghana's Tertiary Education Commission lists 324 accredited tertiary institutions, including 24 chartered private institutions and 98 private institutions teaching degrees or higher national diplomas, alongside 16 traditional public universities and 10 technical universities. Acorn, citing national data, reports that Kenya's chartered universities rose from 34 in 2011 to 67. Egypt's Ministry of Higher Education counts 128 universities for 2025/26, up from 50 in 2014, including 32 national (ahleya) universities after 12 were approved in 2025.

Listed groups are growing with them. In South Africa, STADIO had 56,171 students at June 2026, 10% more than a year earlier. ADvTECH's tertiary division grew revenue 17% to R2.24bn (US$135m) in the first half of 2026 at a 26.4% operating margin, opened a R420m campus in Sandton in February 2026 and began registering students in Ghana in January. Honoris United Universities, which owns Mundiapolis in Casablanca and Nile University of Nigeria, reports more than 85,000 students in 16 institutions across 10 African countries.

None of these counts comes with a housing figure. National student-bed figures for Nigeria, Egypt and Morocco were not available in the public sources we used. The one private campus plan we found with a bed number, ADvTECH's Durban campus for 8,000 students from 2029, includes a 500-bed residence: about six beds for every 100 students, against Kenya's market-wide 44.5.

BRANCH CAMPUSES AND THEIR BEDS

Egypt's new capital hosts four branch-campus hubs, the largest cluster of international branch campuses we found in Africa

EXHIBIT 11

Housing adds 10 to 38% to tuition at the private universities we could price

Published tuition and housing charges at selected private universities and branch campuses, latest academic year; US$ at 2026 rates

INSTITUTION	LOCATION	MODEL	OPENED	PUBLISHED TUITION	HOUSING
American University in Cairo	New Cairo, Egypt	Private non-profit	1919	US$700 per credit hour (Egyptian), US$735 (international), 2025-26	US$1,000 to 2,180 per semester (2026-27)
Four branch-campus hubs: Universities of Canada in Egypt; Global Academic Foundation (Hertfordshire); European Universities in Egypt; The Knowledge Hub (Coventry)	New Administrative Capital, Egypt	International branch campuses; TKH and Hertfordshire on about 50 acres or more	From 2018	Not published on the public pages we fetched	n/p
American University of Nigeria	Yola, Nigeria	Private	n/p	N1,269,840 per semester for 15 credits (US$954)	N270,000 to 487,500 per semester (US$203 to 366)
Ashesi University	Berekuso, Ghana	Private, chartered; about 1,800 students	2002	GHS 53,498 per term (US$4,604), Ghanaian students	GHS 9,435 per term (US$812)
Carnegie Mellon University Africa	Kigali, Rwanda	US university branch	2011	US$16,000 a year (African), US$61,510 (international)	Living costs incl. housing US$345 to 580 a month
International University of Rabat	Rabat-Salé, Morocco	Public-private partnership; 7,300 students (2023-24)	2010	n/p	2,550-bed residence, six halls
ADvTECH Emeris/Vega (planned)	Durban, South Africa	Listed private provider; 8,000 students	2029 (phase one)	n/p	500-bed residence

Source: Institution websites (AUC tuition and residence rates; Universities of Canada in Egypt; GAF; EUE; TKH; AUN undergraduate fees; Ashesi; CMU-Africa; UIR), accessed 2026; Les Inspirations ÉCO (International University of Rabat, 2024); ADvTECH interim results 2026. n/p: not published on the pages fetched.

The New Administrative Capital is the largest cluster of international branch campuses we found in Africa. Universities of Canada in Egypt opened there in 2018 with about 200 students, the first in the city. The University of Hertfordshire followed in 2020; European Universities in Egypt, set up by decree in 2021, hosts the University of London, with academic direction from LSE, the University of Central Lancashire and, since 2024, the University of East London; and The Knowledge Hub hosts Coventry University and NOVA University Lisbon.

Student-bed numbers for the district were not available in the sources we used. The nearest published benchmark is AUC in New Cairo, where a double room adds about 10% to the tuition for 15 credit hours. At Ashesi a term in residence adds about 18% to Ghanaian tuition, and at the American University of Nigeria 21 to 38%. These are products for fee-paying families, a different market from the mass of students behind the seat requirement.

US$250

monthly cost of an AUC double room (US$1,000 per four-month semester). **Heirstone analysis**

50+

feddans on The Knowledge Hub campus; the Hertfordshire campus covers about 50 acres

CHAPTER 3

03 The Heirstone Student City Benchmark

The benchmark sets 15 countries side by side on the measures that decide whether a student city needs seats, beds or both: the size and growth of its 18 to 24 cohort, participation, the seats required by 2035, student mobility in both directions and graduate unemployment.

Every country is measured from the same international sources, so the comparison is like for like. The latest year differs by country and is shown. From it we derive five types of student system, set out on the next two pages.

EXHIBIT 12

Fifteen student systems on one page

Cohort, participation, seat requirement, mobility and graduate unemployment, latest available year

COUNTRY	TYPE	18-24 2025 (M)	18-24 2035 (M)	CHANGE TO 2035	2050 VS 2025	GER % (YEAR)	SEATS TO HOLD GER (000)	SEATS TO REACH 20% (000)	ABROAD 2023 (000)	ABROAD, % OF ENROLMENT	IN PER OUT	GRADUATE UNEMPLOYMENT % (YEAR)
NORTH AFRICA												
Egypt	SURGE	14.1	18.0	+28%	+21%	38.0 (2025)	1,066	0	68.0	2.0%	1.84	13.2 (2024)
Algeria	SURGE	4.4	6.6	+51%	+21%	54.4 (2024)	840	0	38.3	2.3%	0.15	9.7 (2014)
Morocco	PLATEAU	4.2	4.5	+7%	−6%	48.2 (2024)	105	0	75.2	5.3%	0.36	25.9 (2022)
Tunisia	PLATEAU	1.1	1.5	+27%	−14%	38.1 (2023)	82	0	29.4	9.6%	0.32	21.7 (2023)
WEST AND CENTRAL AFRICA												
Nigeria	PRESSURE	33.1	42.7	+29%	+46%	9.7* (2011)	1,455*	4,581*	146.3	n/a	n/p	9.2 (2024)
Ghana	TRANSITION	4.6	5.5	+20%	+29%	21.3 (2024)	141	89	23.8	3.4%	0.22	5.7 (2024)
Côte d'Ivoire	PRESSURE	4.2	6.0	+42%	+70%	12.3 (2024)	145	450	18.7	5.9%	0.40	10.5 (2022)
Senegal	QUEUE	2.6	3.0	+15%	+39%	15.3 (2024)	42	140	19.5	6.8%	1.32†	13.6 (2024)
Cameroon	PRESSURE	4.0	5.1	+30%	+66%	16.7 (2024)	134	250	33.8	8.1%	0.22	18.8 (2021)
EAST AFRICA												
Kenya	QUEUE	8.3	9.3	+12%	+25%	10.4 (2024)	75	706	23.2	4.7%	n/p	7.7 (2022)
Ethiopia	QUEUE	19.5	22.6	+16%	+52%	5.9* (2014)	370*	2,647*	11.1	n/a	n/p	10.6 (2021)
Uganda	QUEUE	7.4	8.9	+21%	+50%	4.6* (2014)	129*	1,107*	7.1	n/a	n/p	9.9 (2021)
Tanzania	PRESSURE	9.5	12.3	+28%	+77%	4.0 (2024)	72	1,359	7.9	2.5%	0.13	5.5 (2024)
Rwanda	QUEUE	2.1	2.3	+13%	+34%	9.4 (2024)	17	183	7.3	6.1%	1.12	11.4 (2024)
SOUTHERN AFRICA												
South Africa	TRANSITION	7.3	7.8	+7%	+17%	23.5 (2023)	83	0	13.3	1.1%	2.90	12.8 (2024)
Total, 15		**126.4**	**156.2**	**+24%**	**+41%**		**4,754***	**11,513***	**522.8**			

Source: Heirstone Student City Benchmark 2026. UNESCO UIS (GER.5T8, 25053, OE.5T8.40510, 26637; Feb 2026); World Bank Population Estimates and Projections (source 40, Jul 2026); World Bank WDI SL.UEM.ADVN.ZS (ILO-modelled). *Estimated: ratio and enrolment last reported in 2011 (Nigeria) or 2014 (Ethiopia, Uganda); seats use five sevenths of the 18 to 24 cohort as base population. †Senegal inbound for 2023. Graduate unemployment: unemployment among the labour force with advanced education. n/a: no current enrolment; n/p: not published. **Heirstone analysis.**

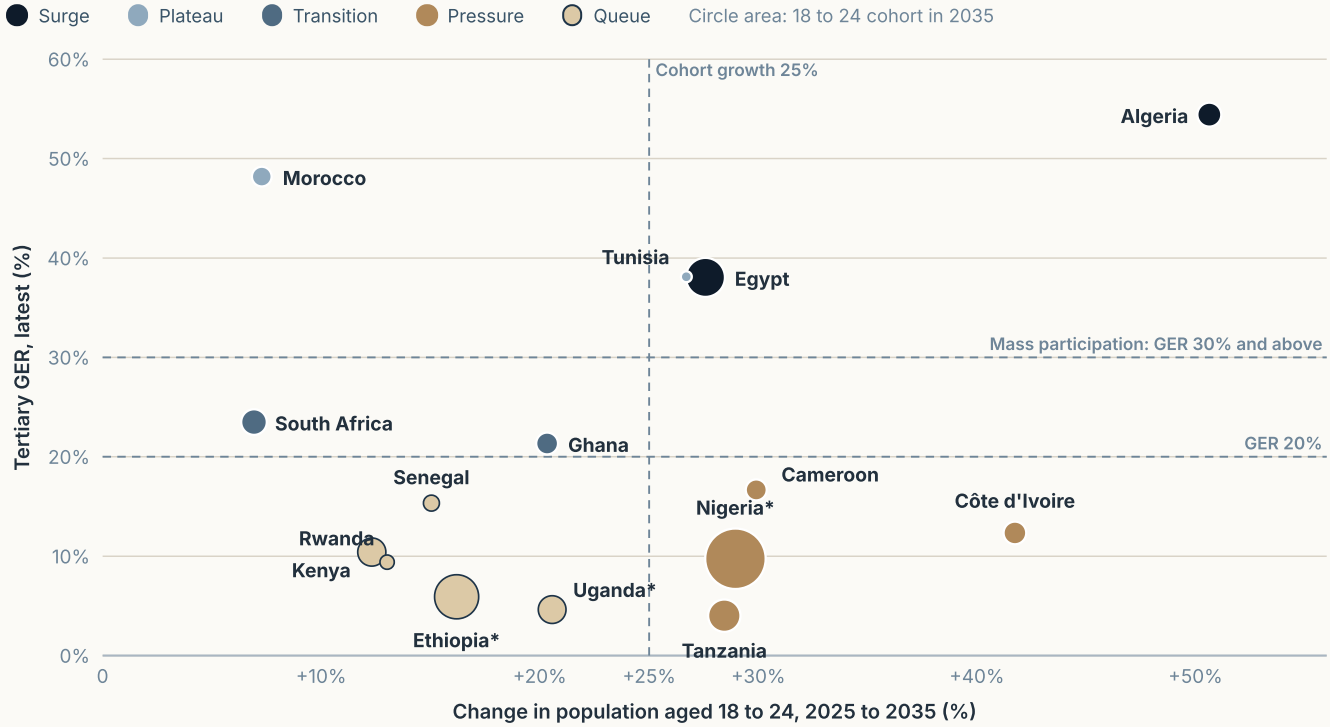
FIVE STUDENT SYSTEMS

Two measures, participation and cohort growth, sort the 15 countries into five types of student system

EXHIBIT 13

Two systems combine mass participation with fast cohort growth; four combine fast growth with participation below 20%

Tertiary GER, latest year, against change in population aged 18 to 24, 2025 to 2035



Source: Heirstone Student City Benchmark 2026 (Exhibit 12). Types applied in this order: **Plateau**, 18 to 24 cohort smaller in 2050 than in 2025; **Surge**, GER 30% or more; **Transition**, GER 20 to 30%; **Pressure**, GER below 20% and cohort growth to 2035 of 25% or more; **Queue**, GER below 20% and growth below 25%. *Ratio for 2011 or 2014. **Heirstone analysis.**

READING THE BENCHMARK

The types are deliberately simple. Two published measures place each country, and a third, the cohort in 2050, separates the North African systems that will keep growing from those that will not. Mobility cuts across the types: Nigeria, Cameroon and Côte d'Ivoire are Pressure systems that also lose students abroad, while Rwanda and Senegal are Queue systems that attract them.

Two countries hold two thirds of the seats needed to keep pace.

Egypt and Algeria need 1.91 million of the 2.8 million seats required to hold ratios in the 12 countries with current data.

The largest gaps sit where the data is oldest.

Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda account for about 8.3 million of the 11.5 million seats needed to reach 20%, on estimates built from enrolment last reported in 2011 and 2014.

Graduate unemployment is highest in the two Plateau systems.

It reached 25.9% in Morocco (2022) and 21.7% in Tunisia (2023), against 5.5 to 13.6% in the Sub-Saharan systems with 2024 data.

Net importers are a minority.

Only Egypt, South Africa, Rwanda and Senegal take in more international students than they send.

THE TYPOLOGY

Each type of student system needs a different kind of building

The types matter for real estate because they change what should be built and at what price. A Surge system needs volume. A Plateau system needs buildings that can change use once the cohort shrinks, and a Queue system needs beds that students on public places can afford.

Surge

GER 30% or more; cohort still larger in 2050 than in 2025

Egypt, Algeria

Ratios of 38% and 54%; cohorts grow 28% and 51% to 2035. Together they need 1.91 million seats to hold their ratios. Egypt also hosts 1.8 international students for every one it sends.

WHAT GETS BUILT

Volume: public and national-university seats, mid-market beds near new university clusters, and an international tier in Cairo.

Plateau

Cohort smaller in 2050 than in 2025

Morocco, Tunisia

Ratios of 48% and 38%; cohorts 6.5% and 14% smaller by 2050 than in 2025. Graduate unemployment of 25.9% and 21.7%. Students abroad equal 5.3% and 9.6% of enrolment.

WHAT GETS BUILT

Quality and employability; branch campuses to win students back; residences designed from the start to convert to young-professional rental or hotel use after 2035.

Transition

GER 20 to 30%

South Africa, Ghana

Ratios of 23.5% and 21.3%. South Africa's cohort grows 7% to 2035; it hosts 2.9 students for each it sends, and its state bursary scheme covers accommodation. Ghana's grows 20% and it sends 4.6 for each it hosts.

WHAT GETS BUILT

South Africa: beds priced and accredited for bursary-funded students, and public programmes such as SHIP. Ghana: private universities with housing priced in cedis.

Pressure

GER below 20%; cohort growth of 25% or more to 2035

Nigeria, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon, Tanzania

Ratios of 4% to 17%; cohorts grow 28% to 42% to 2035 and 46% to 77% by 2050. The largest seat gaps: about 4.6 million for Nigeria (estimated) and 1.36 million for Tanzania to reach 20%. Nigeria sends more students abroad than any other country in the set.

WHAT GETS BUILT

Seats first, through private universities and branch campuses, with affordable beds attached; a deliberate effort to keep outbound students at home.

Queue

GER below 20%; cohort growth under 25% to 2035

Kenya, Ethiopia, Uganda, Rwanda, Senegal

Ratios of 4.6% to 15.3%; cohorts grow 12% to 21% to 2035. Qualified school leavers outrun places: Kenya's rose 56% in three years. Rwanda and Senegal take in more international students than they send.

WHAT GETS BUILT

Places at public universities and affordable beds beside them: the Nairobi model of a premium and an affordable tier in one scheme.

Sources: Heirstone Student City Benchmark 2026 (Exhibit 12); UNESCO UIS; World Bank; ILO-modelled unemployment via World Bank WDI. South Africa's bursary scheme (NSFAS) pays for accommodation at the cost the university charges, plus transport, living and book allowances, according to NSFAS.

CHAPTER 4



04

What a bed earns

Kenya is the one market in this report where student-housing returns can be tested asset by asset, from a listed operator's annual reports.

12,738

operating beds in Acorn's two Nairobi-listed student-housing REITs at the end of 2025, with 6,345 more in the pipeline

The usual case for African student housing rests on demographics and a large national bed deficit. Acorn's own estimate of Kenya's gap is 300,000 beds. Neither number says whether a particular building will fill, at what rent, or what it is worth once it has.

Kenya can answer those questions because a student-housing operator there is listed. Acorn's development REIT (D-REIT) builds: at the end of 2025 it had 14 projects with more than 14,500 beds operating or under development, 8,198 of them open. Its income REIT (I-REIT) owns seven stabilised Qwetu residences in Nairobi with 4,540 beds, housing students from 207 institutions. Between them they publish occupancy, rents, costs, debt and valuations by property.

South Africa adds published rates. Respublica, founded in 2011, runs about 9,900 beds in 11 residences across six cities, and the state's Student Housing Infrastructure Programme publishes what it has spent per bed. Elsewhere, university-owned residences at AUC, Ashesi and the American University of Nigeria publish their charges. These are the inputs for the next three pages.

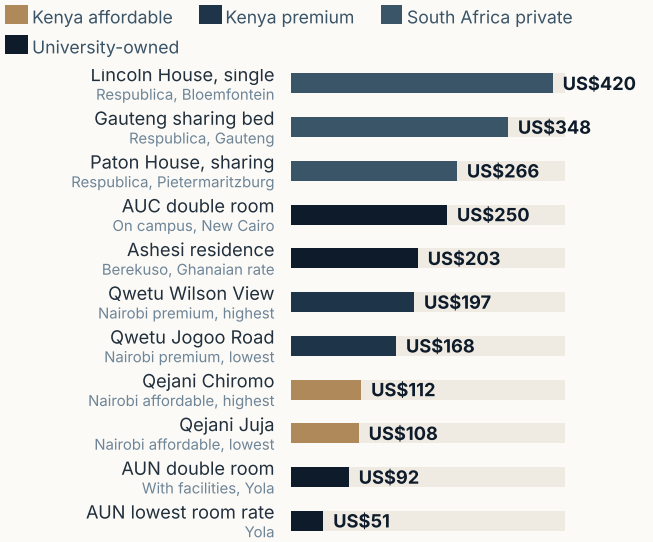
RENT

A bed in Nairobi's affordable tier costs about US$110 a month. A Gauteng sharing bed costs about US$348.

EXHIBIT 14

South African private beds cost 2.4 to 3.9 times Nairobi's affordable tier in dollars

Rent per bed per month, US$ at 2026 rates; published "from" or average rates

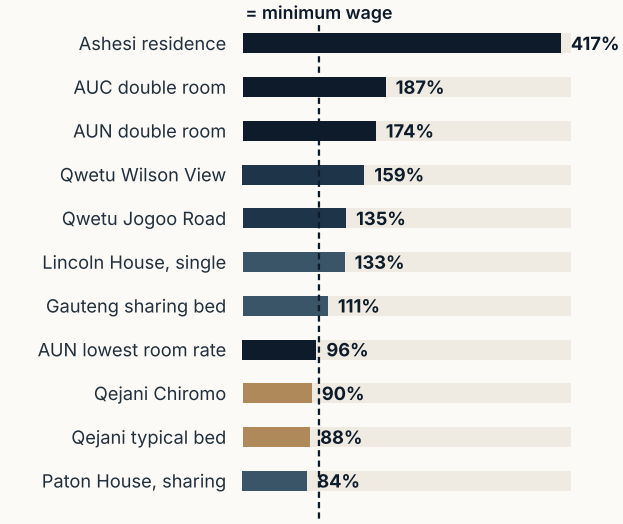


Source: ASA I-REIT and D-REIT 2025 annual reports (FY2025 rents and estimated rental values); Respublica 2027 rates; AUC residence rates 2026-27; Ashesi; AUN fees 2026/27. Semester and term charges divided by four months. **Heirstone analysis.**

EXHIBIT 15

Only Nairobi's affordable tier and the cheapest South African and Nigerian rooms sit at or below the minimum wage

Monthly rent per bed as % of the local statutory monthly minimum wage



Source: As Exhibit 14. Minimum wages: Kenya KES 16,113.75 (LN 164/2024, via WageIndicator); South Africa R30.23 an hour in 2026 × 173.3 hours (EWN, 2026); Nigeria N70,000 (Channels Television, 2024); Egypt EGP 7,000 private sector (Cairo Governorate, 2025); Ghana GHS 21.77 a day x 26 days (WageIndicator). **Heirstone analysis.**

A rent means little until it is set against what students, or whoever funds them, can pay. We compare each published rent with the statutory monthly minimum wage, the one income benchmark available in almost every country covered; we found no current figure for Rwanda. Acorn's affordable Qejani beds rent for KES 14,014 to 14,524 a month, about US$108 to 112 and 87 to 90% of Kenya's monthly minimum wage of KES 16,113.75 (Legal Notice 164 of 2024, as compiled by WageIndicator). Its premium Qwetu beds, at KES 21,736 to 25,554, cost 135 to 159%.

In South Africa, Respublica's 2027 rates start at R4,423 a month in Pietermaritzburg and R5,800 for a sharing bed in Gauteng, about US$266 and US$348, on leases of at least ten months. On a 40-hour week the national minimum wage of R30.23 an hour set for 2026 is about R5,240 a month, so the Gauteng bed costs 111% of it. Five Respublica residences are accredited by NSFAS, the state bursary scheme, and most quote an NSFAS rate. For funded students, the scheme's accommodation allowance limits what a bed can earn.

University-owned housing at the top of the market is priced for fee-paying families. AUC, a top-of-market private university, charges about US$250 a month for a double, 187% of Egypt's private-sector minimum wage of EGP 7,000, set by the National Wages Council for 2025; Egypt's public university residences are outside this comparison. An Ashesi room costs about 4.2 times Ghana's minimum wage of GHS 21.77 a day over a 26-day working month (as compiled by WageIndicator).

> *An affordable bed in Nairobi rents for less than a month of Kenya's minimum wage. A sharing bed in Gauteng rents for more than a month of South Africa's.*

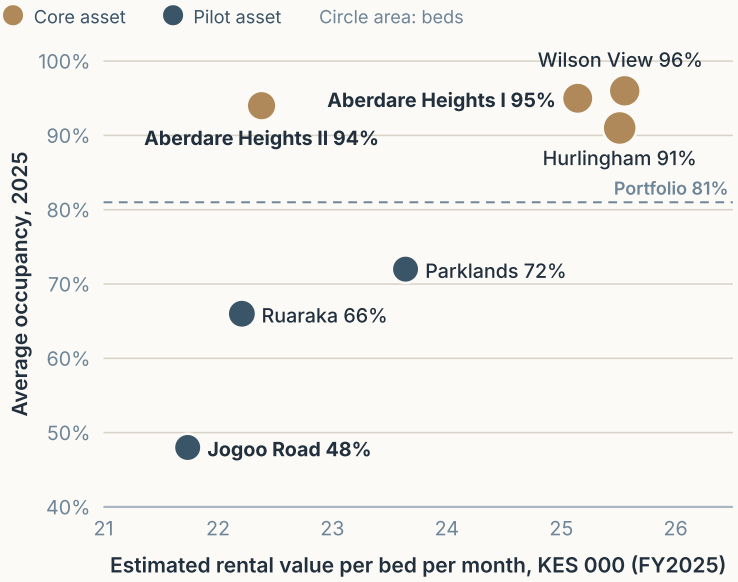
OCCUPANCY AND MIX

In Nairobi, occupancy in 2025 tracked access to campus and the state of the building more closely than the rent

EXHIBIT 16

Rents differ by less than a fifth across the seven blocks; occupancy ran from 48% to 96%

Seven stabilised Qwetu residences: estimated rental value per bed against average occupancy in 2025

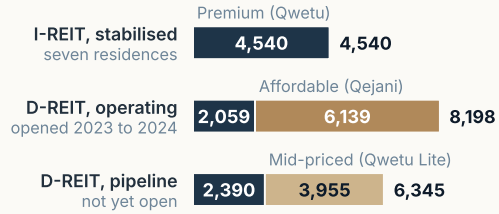


Source: ASA I-REIT 2025 Annual Report (property highlights, valuation table, occupancy by property; core and pilot as classified by the manager).

EXHIBIT 17

Three in four beds the development REIT has opened are in the affordable tier

Acorn student beds by tier and stage, end-2025



Source: ASA I-REIT and D-REIT 2025 annual reports. Pipeline uses 1,680 beds for Qwetu Lite CBD (pipeline table); the portfolio summary gives 1,398. **Heirstone analysis.**

Acorn's stabilised portfolio averaged 81% occupancy in 2025. The manager splits it in two: 94% across four core assets and 62% across three pilot assets. Property by property, the gap does not follow price. Aberdare Heights II, near USIU-Africa, had one of the lowest rental values in the portfolio, KES 22,380 a bed, and ran at 94%. Jogoo Road, the cheapest at KES 21,736, ran at 48%: Acorn cites poor road access and repair works, and the block sits just beyond 2.5 km from the main institutions. Ruaraka lost bookings when a key institutional partner changed its commitment, and Parklands had repair works.

Income follows occupancy. Residential income of KES 1,034.4m in 2025 works out at about KES 18,990 per bed per month, 74 to 87% of the properties' estimated rental values. Gross income was about 9.6% of the value of the investment property and the EPRA net initial yield 6.7%, which implies operating costs of about 30% of gross income.

The development pipeline has moved down the price ladder. Of the 8,198 beds the D-REIT opened in 2023 and 2024, 6,139 (75%) are affordable Qejani beds built in the same complexes as premium Qwetu beds. Of the 6,345 in the pipeline, 3,955 (62%) are mid-priced Qwetu Lite, including the first schemes beyond the Nairobi area, in Eldoret and Kakamega.

6.7%

EPRA net initial yield on the stabilised portfolio, 2025

KES 18,990

realised residential income per bed per month in 2025 (US$147). **Heirstone analysis**

+30%

growth in the I-REIT's distribution per unit in 2025, to KES 0.86

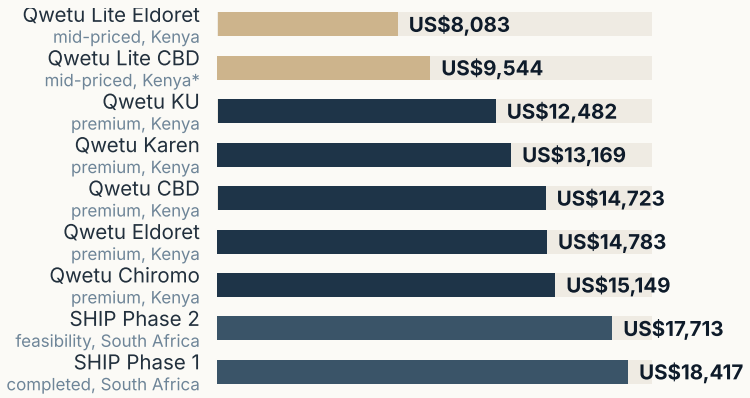
COST AND CAPITAL

Nairobi builds a premium bed for US$12,500 to 15,100. South Africa's state programme paid about US$18,400.

EXHIBIT 18

Kenya's listed developer builds for less per bed than South Africa's public programme

Development cost per bed, US$ at 2026 rates



Source: ASA D-REIT 2025 Annual Report (total development cost and beds by scheme); DBSA, Student Housing Infrastructure Programme. *Qwetu Lite CBD on the portfolio summary's 1,398 beds. SHIP figures are total programme investment divided by beds. **Heirstone analysis.**

Acorn's premium Qwetu schemes cost KES 1.6m to 2.0m a bed to develop, about US$12,500 to 15,100, and its mid-priced Qwetu Lite scheme in Eldoret about KES 1.05m (US$8,100). South Africa's Student Housing Infrastructure Programme, run by the Department of Higher Education and Training with the Development Bank of Southern Africa as implementing agent, completed 11,407 beds in its first phase for R3.5bn: about R307,000, or US$18,400, a bed. Phase 2 feasibility studies cover 24,398 beds for about R7.2bn, roughly R295,000 a bed.

The comparison is not exact. SHIP builds on campus for public universities and TVET colleges, and its figure is total investment. It still gives ministries a yardstick for public-private tenders.

Costs and rents can be read together. A premium Nairobi bed costs 5.7 to 6.5 years of its gross rent at full occupancy. The D-REIT's valuers put its affordable beds at about KES 1.18m to 1.27m each (US$9,100 to 9,800), 7.0 to 7.3 years of their rent. Valuation yields on cost across the D-REIT range from about 4.6% at Qejani Hurlingham to 10.5% at Qwetu Karen.

The capital came from local banks and development finance. The D-REIT's construction facility from Absa was KES 6.7bn in 2023, upsized to KES 7.73bn for Eldoret, and borrowings stood at 46.5% of asset value against a 60% limit. InfraCo Africa, part of PIDG, holds 10.13% of the I-REIT and 5.7% of the D-REIT. The green bond that financed Acorn's first projects, before a 2024 refinancing, carried a GuarantCo guarantee on 50% of principal and interest. SHIP's first phase used R1.6bn of DBSA debt, about 46% of its cost; Phase 2 assumes roughly 40%.

KES 7.73bn

Absa construction facility for Acorn's D-REIT, in shillings (US$60m)

46.5%

D-REIT borrowings as a share of asset value, against a 60% limit

50%

of principal and interest on Acorn's green bond guaranteed by GuarantCo



CHAPTER 5

05 The Heirstone Student Bed Test

Six questions decide whether a student residence in an African city will fill and pay. Each comes from the operating evidence in this report, and each can be answered before land is bought.

1 **Anchor.** Is there a growing campus within walking distance that will send students?

Acorn's core assets ran at 94% occupancy in 2025 and its pilots at 62%; its emptiest block sits just beyond 2.5 km from the main institutions. Respublica's largest residence, Hatfield Square, with 2,331 beds, is 200 metres from the University of Pretoria; Paton House is 40 metres from UKZN in Pietermaritzburg.

2 **Rent fit.** Does the rent fit whoever pays it?

For a mass product, at or below the monthly minimum wage, as Nairobi's affordable beds are (87 to 90%). Where a bursary pays, within its allowance. For fee-paying students, a modest addition to tuition: 10 to 38% at the private universities we priced.

3 **Runway.** Will the 18 to 24 cohort still be larger in 2050 than in 2025?

If not, as in Morocco and Tunisia, the building needs a second use designed in from the start.

4 **Cost.** Does the bed cost no more than about seven years of its gross rent?

Nairobi's premium beds cost 5.7 to 6.5 years of rent to build, and its affordable beds are valued at 7.0 to 7.3 years. The threshold is a Heirstone benchmark from these figures.

5 **Capital.** Is the debt in the currency of the rent, at about half of value or less?

Acorn's D-REIT borrows in shillings at 46.5% of value; SHIP's first phase was 46% DBSA debt.

6 **Exit.** Who buys the stabilised asset?

A REIT, a listed operator or a university lease: Acorn's I-REIT, Respublica's purchase of 582 Stellenbosch beds in October 2025, UCT's lease of Roscommon House.

THE TEST APPLIED

Applied to six cases, the test favours the affordable bed beside a public campus. Elsewhere, most of the inputs are not published.

EXHIBIT 19

Only Nairobi's affordable tier passes on almost every count; outside Kenya, half the answers are missing from the public record

The Heirstone Student Bed Test applied to six reference cases, on published information at 2026

● passes ◐ partly ○ fails N/P not published

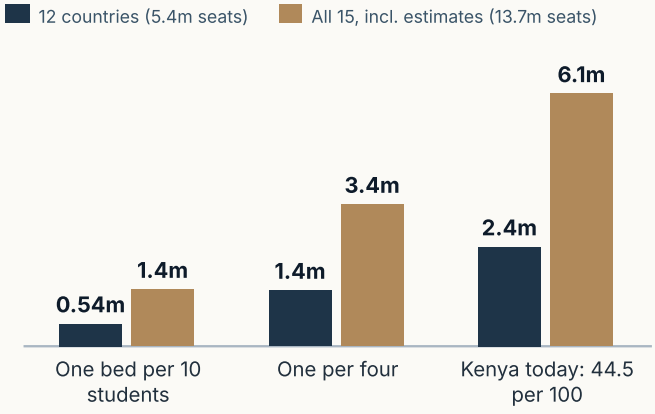
CASE	1. ANCHOR	2. RENT FIT	3. RUNWAY	4. COST	5. CAPITAL	6. EXIT
Nairobi affordable tier Qejani, beside public campuses	● UoN Chiromo, Kenyatta, JKUAT	● 87 to 90% of minimum wage	● Kenya cohort +25% by 2050	● Valued at 7.0 to 7.3 years of rent	● KES debt, 46.5% LTV; DFI partners	◐ REIT route exists; I-REIT holds premium only so far
Nairobi premium pilot Qwetu Jogoo Road	○ Beyond 2.5 km of main campuses; 48% occupancy	◐ 135% of minimum wage	● Kenya cohort +25% by 2050	N/P Acquired; cost not shown	● Inside the listed I-REIT	● Already in the I-REIT
Gauteng private residence Respublica sharing bed	● 200 m from UP and UJ	◐ 111% of minimum wage; NSFAS-accredited	◐ Cohort +7% to 2035, +17% to 2050	N/P Private cost unpublished	N/P Not published	● MySpace purchase; UCT lease
Cairo international campus housing AUC; New Administrative Capital hubs	● Four branch-campus hubs; two on about 50 acres	◐ About 10% of tuition; 187% of minimum wage	● Cohort +28% to 2035, +21% by 2050	N/P Not published	N/P Not published	○ No published bed stock or deals
Nigerian private-university housing AUN as the priced reference	◐ 182 private universities, many licensed in 2026	◐ 96 to 174% of minimum wage; 21 to 38% of tuition	● Cohort +29% to 2035, +46% by 2050	N/P Not published	N/P Not published	○ No published hostel stock or deals
Tunis or Rabat campus housing Public cités; UIR residential campus	◐ About 30 public cités in Morocco; UIR's 2,550 beds	N/P Rents and current wage data not published	○ Cohort smaller in 2050 than in 2025	N/P Not published	N/P Not published	○ No cité capacities or deals published

Source: Heirstone Student Bed Test 2026, using the sources in Chapters 1 to 4: ASA I-REIT and D-REIT 2025 annual reports; Respublica; DBSA; AUC; AUN; NUC; ONOUSC; World Bank population projections; minimum wages as Exhibit 15. **Heirstone analysis.**

EXHIBIT 20

At Kenya's ratio of beds to students, the 2035 seat requirement implies 2.4 to 6.1 million beds

Beds implied by the 2035 seat requirement (hold GER or reach 20%, whichever is higher) at three residential shares, millions



Source: Heirstone Student City Benchmark 2026; ASA D-REIT 2025 Annual Report (Kenya ratio). **Heirstone analysis.** Shares are illustrative.

Outside Kenya, no country in this report publishes the share of students who live away from home or the number of beds available to them. The sensitivity in Exhibit 20 shows the scale instead. At one bed for every ten new students, the 5.4 million seats needed in the 12 countries with current data imply about 540,000 beds. At Kenya's present ratio of 44.5 beds per 100 students they imply 2.4 million.

At Nairobi's development costs of US$8,100 to 15,100 a bed, every 100,000 beds represents US$0.8bn to 1.5bn of investment. Costs elsewhere will differ, and in South Africa the public benchmark is higher.

CHAPTER 6

06

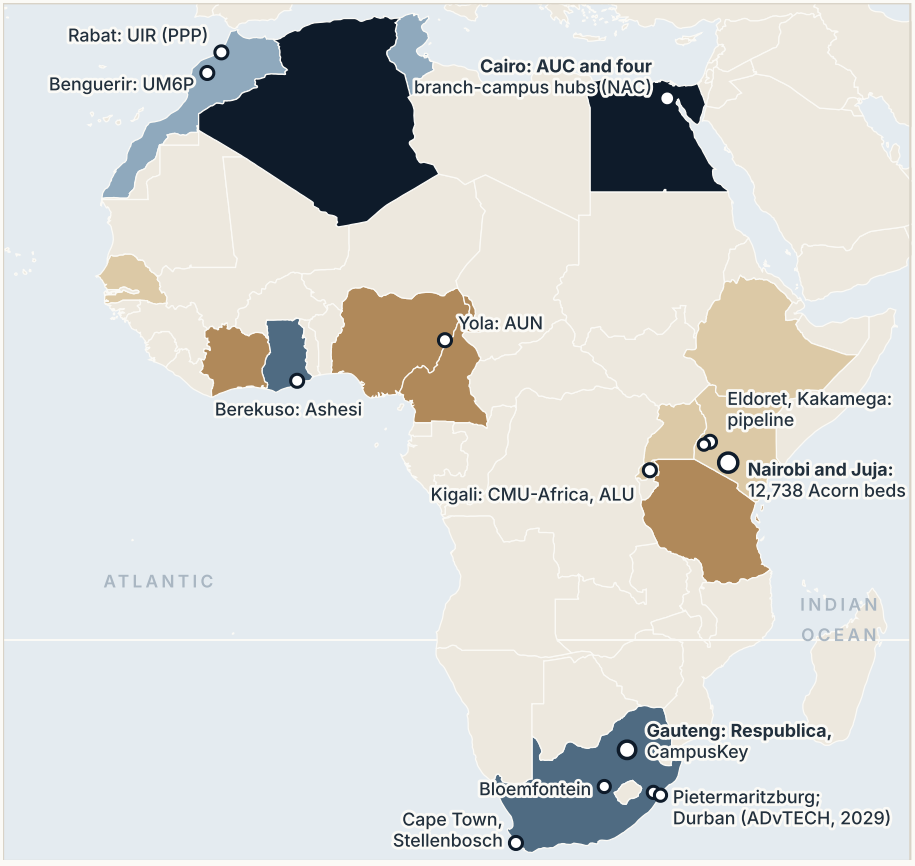
North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa

The five types cut across the usual regional lines. What follows takes each country in turn, north to south, with what the published evidence supports and what it does not.

EXHIBIT 21

Where the five student systems are, and where named campus and housing investments sit

Heirstone student-system type by country; universities, branch-campus hubs and student-housing schemes named in this report



STUDENT-SYSTEM TYPES

Surge
Egypt, Algeria

Plateau
Morocco, Tunisia

Transition
South Africa, Ghana

Pressure
Nigeria, Côte d'Ivoire, Tanzania, Cameroon

Queue
Kenya, Ethiopia, Senegal, Rwanda, Uganda

Unshaded countries are outside the benchmark. White circles mark the named institutions and schemes discussed in Chapters 2 to 5.

Source: Heirstone Student City Benchmark 2026; ASA REIT 2025 annual reports; Respublica; CampusKey; ADvTECH; AUC; NAC hub websites; AUN; Ashesi; CMU-Africa; ALU; OpenStreetMap via Mapcarta (UIR, UM6P). Positions approximate. Boundaries: Natural Earth.

18 TO 24 YEAR-OLDS ADDED BETWEEN 2025 AND 2035, BY REGION

+6.7m
North Africa: 23.9m to 30.6m, a rise of 28%. Heirstone analysis

+13.9m
West and Central Africa: 48.5m to 62.3m, a rise of 29%. Heirstone analysis

+8.7m
East Africa: 46.8m to 55.5m, a rise of 19%. Heirstone analysis

+0.5m
Southern Africa: 7.3m to 7.8m, a rise of 7%. Heirstone analysis

NORTH AFRICA

North Africa has two surges and two plateaus. Egypt, with 3.87 million students, is the largest system of the four.

Egypt: the largest volume, and an exporter

Egypt is the largest student-housing question in North Africa. Its universities enrolled 3.87 million students in 2025, 32% more than in 2017, and its ratio rose from 32.9% in 2015 to 38.0%. Its 18 to 24 cohort rises from 14.1 million to 18.0 million by 2035. Holding the current ratio of 38% needs about 1.07 million more seats; if one in ten of those students needed a bed away from home, that alone would be about 107,000 beds. Capacity is coming from national (ahleya) universities, which number 32 after 12 were approved in 2025, among them Galala University, designed for 12,750 students in three phases, and from the branch-campus hubs of the New Administrative Capital; residence capacity and private beds around these campuses were not available in the sources we used. Egypt is also an exporter of education, with 125,128 international students in 2024, 79% more than in 2022.

Algeria: the sharpest rise

Algeria has the highest participation in the benchmark, 54.4%, and the sharpest demographic rise: its 18 to 24 cohort grows 51% to 6.6 million by 2035. Holding the ratio needs about 840,000 more seats, the second-largest requirement after Egypt. Algerians abroad nearly doubled between 2015 and 2023, to 38,304, while 5,746 international students came the other way. We found no comparable public data on student housing.

Morocco: from access to employability

Morocco raised its ratio from 28.6% in 2015 to 48.2% in 2024 and now enrols 1.44 million students. Its cohort grows only 7% to 2035 and is smaller than today's by 2050. The pressing issue is employability: 25.9% of the tertiary-educated labour force was unemployed in 2022. Students abroad reached 75,186 in 2023. The public residence office, ONOUSC, lists about 30 cités universitaires in 16 cities but publishes no capacities. The International University of Rabat, founded in 2010 as a public-private partnership on land provided by the State, had 7,300 students in 2023-24 and a 30-hectare campus with a 2,550-bed residence.

Tunisia: a bulge to design around

Tunisia's cohort grows 27% to 1.45 million in 2035, then falls to 0.99 million by 2050, about a third below the 2035 level. Enrolment of 305,918 in 2023 was still below the 2015 level. Tunisia sends abroad the equivalent of 9.6% of its students, the highest share in the benchmark, and 21.7% of its tertiary-educated workforce was unemployed in 2023. Beds built for the bulge around 2035 should be designed from the outset for a second use, such as rental for young professionals or hotel accommodation.

18.0m

Egyptians aged 18 to 24 in 2035, up from 14.1m in 2025

107,000

beds if one in ten of Egypt's additional students needed one. **Heirstone sensitivity**

6.6m

Algerians aged 18 to 24 in 2035, 51% more than in 2025

25.9%

unemployment among Morocco's tertiary-educated labour force, 2022

−32%

fall in Tunisia's 18 to 24 cohort from 2035 to 2050

WEST AND CENTRAL AFRICA

West and Central Africa holds the largest cohorts and the largest outflows, and the least housing data

Nigeria

Nigeria will have 42.7 million people aged 18 to 24 in 2035 and 48.3 million in 2050. Its universities are multiplying, to 328 in 2026, 182 of them private, and its students are leaving in growing numbers: 146,286 were abroad in 2023. On our estimate it needs 3.9 to 4.6 million more seats to reach a 20% ratio by 2035. We found no national figure for hostel beds. At the American University of Nigeria in Yola, a semester in residence costs N270,000 to 487,500, about N67,500 to 121,875 a month, or 96 to 174% of the N70,000 national minimum wage (set by law in 2024). At NGN 1,331.28 to the dollar that is US$51 to 92 a month, the cheapest university housing we priced in dollar terms.

Ghana

Ghana crossed 20% participation in 2024 (21.3%, from 15.6% in 2015), with 693,463 students, and its cohort grows 20% to 2035. GTEC lists 324 accredited tertiary institutions, and ADvTECH began registering students at a Ghanaian institution in January 2026. Ghana sends 4.6 students abroad for every international student it hosts. Ashesi, a private university of about 1,800 students in Berekuso, charges GHS 9,435 (US$812) a term for housing.

Côte d'Ivoire

Côte d'Ivoire's cohort grows 42% to 6.0 million by 2035, faster than any other Sub-Saharan country in the benchmark, and to 7.2 million by 2050. Participation rose from 8.5% to 12.3% between 2015 and 2024, and enrolment from 217,914 in 2017 to 346,786. Reaching 20% by 2035 needs about 450,000 more seats; holding today's ratio alone needs 145,000. Ivorians abroad numbered 18,675 in 2023, equal to 5.9% of that year's domestic enrolment. On these numbers Côte d'Ivoire is one of the largest francophone opportunities for private universities and student housing in this report, and one of the least documented.

Senegal

Senegal enrols 279,917 students, a ratio of 15.3%, up from 10.8% in 2015. It sends the equivalent of 6.8% of its students abroad but, on 2023 figures, hosts more international students (25,658) than it sends (19,498). UNESCO's 2024 figure of 83,758 looks like a break in the series and should not be relied on.

Cameroon

Cameroon enrols 447,513 students (16.7%), and its cohort grows 30% to 2035 and 66% by 2050. It sent 33,755 students abroad in 2023, equal to 8.1% of that year's enrolment, the second-highest share in the benchmark, and 18.8% of its tertiary-educated workforce was unemployed in 2021. Reaching 20% needs about 250,000 more seats.

48.3m

Nigerians aged 18 to 24 in 2050

US$51-92

monthly cost of university housing at AUN in Yola, at NGN 1,331.28 to the dollar

6.0m

Ivorians aged 18 to 24 in 2035, 42% more than in 2025

8.1%

Cameroon's students abroad as a share of domestic enrolment, 2023

EAST AND SOUTHERN AFRICA

East and Southern Africa hold the only student-housing markets in this report that can be priced from published data

Kenya

Kenya is the reference market in this report because it is the only one with a listed student-housing operator that publishes asset-level data. On Acorn's figures it has about 44.5 beds per 100 university students (280,000 beds for 628,541 students in 2024/25), before counting 709,885 TVET students, and Acorn puts the national gap at 300,000 beds. Its two REITs run 12,738 beds with 6,345 in the pipeline, the first beyond the Nairobi area in Eldoret and Kakamega. The qualifier surge (270,715 in 2025) and a ratio of 10.4% point to sustained demand; Jogoo Road's 48% occupancy, at a block Acorn describes as just beyond 2.5 km from the main institutions, shows that access to campus still matters.

Rwanda

Rwanda nearly doubled enrolment in five years, from 72,128 in 2019 to 130,474 in 2024, and hosts more international students than it sends. Kigali has Carnegie Mellon University Africa, which charges African students US$16,000 a year and estimates living costs at US$345 to 580 a month, and African Leadership University at about US$3,000 a year. We found no current statutory minimum wage for Rwanda, so a rent test there needs another income measure.

Tanzania, Ethiopia and Uganda

Tanzania (4.0%), Ethiopia (5.9%, 2014) and Uganda (4.6%, 2014) have the lowest participation in the benchmark and some of the longest runways: by 2050 their cohorts are 77%, 52% and 50% larger than in 2025. Ethiopia's 2014 enrolment differs between UNESCO (587,015) and the World Bank archive (757,175), and Tanzania's series is volatile. Reaching 20% would need about 1.4 million more seats in Tanzania and, on estimated bases, 2.6 million in Ethiopia and 1.1 million in Uganda.

South Africa

South Africa's ratio has been flat at about 23% since 2018 and its cohort grows only 7% to 2035, yet it has the most developed private student-housing market among the 15 countries. Respublica runs about 9,900 beds and bought 582 more in Stellenbosch in October 2025; CampusKey operates near universities in six cities. The state programme SHIP has completed 11,407 beds and studied 24,398 more. Private rents of R4,423 to 6,990 a month equal 84 to 133% of the minimum wage, and several operators' residences are NSFAS-accredited. ADvTECH's plan for 500 beds at an 8,000-student campus in Durban shows private higher education adding beds at a far lower ratio than Kenya's market average.

44.5

beds per 100 university students in Kenya, 2024/25. **Heirstone analysis**

+81%

growth in Rwanda's tertiary enrolment, 2019 to 2024

+77%

Tanzania's 18 to 24 cohort by 2050 against 2025

11,407

beds completed in phase one of South Africa's SHIP

CHAPTER 7

07 Plan the bed with the seat

The seat gap is large and well known. The housing that should come with it is barely measured. Where it is measured, in Nairobi, occupancy depends on access to a campus and rents are set close to what students or their funders can pay.

FOR

Ministries of higher education and regulators

Attach a housing plan to every new university licence and branch-campus approval: on-campus, public-private or accredited private beds, with a number. Nigeria added 103 private universities in seven years without a published national bed count.

Buy beds by the unit. South Africa's SHIP paid about US$18,400 a bed; Nairobi's listed developer builds premium beds for US$12,500 to 15,100 and mid-priced ones for about US$8,100. Use per-bed benchmarks in public-private tenders.

Publish the denominators: enrolment by institution, the capacity and fees of public university residences, and accredited private beds.

Treat students abroad as a market to win back, above all in Tunisia (9.6% of enrolment abroad), Cameroon (8.1%) and Senegal (6.8%).

FOR

Universities and branch-campus sponsors

Sign the housing partner before the first intake. Durban's planned campus pairs 8,000 students with 500 beds; two of the three fullest blocks in Acorn's stabilised Nairobi portfolio stand near USIU-Africa.

Publish housing prices with tuition. At AUC, Ashesi and AUN, housing adds 10 to 38% to the tuition bill.

Offer operators what makes a residence fill: land, referral agreements or a head lease, as UCT does at Roscommon House.

FOR

Developers and operators

Choose the campus before the city: Acorn's core assets ran at 94% occupancy in 2025 and its pilots at 62%, with the emptiest block just beyond 2.5 km from the main institutions.

Where the cohort will shrink, as in Tunisia and Morocco after 2035, design for a second use from the start.

Build two or three price tiers in one scheme, as Acorn does with Qwetu, Qwetu Lite and Qejani; three quarters of the beds its development REIT has opened are affordable.

Where the state pays, get accredited: five Respublica residences are NSFAS-accredited and most quote an NSFAS rate.

FOR

Investors, development finance institutions and banks

Underwrite the anchor campus and the rent-to-wage ratio, and treat national deficit estimates as context.

Lend in the currency of the rent and share risk at portfolio level, as GuarantCo's 50% bond guarantee and InfraCo Africa's REIT stakes have done.

Use Nairobi as the yardstick: a 6.7% net initial yield and 9.6% gross at 81% occupancy in the income REIT, and development REIT debt at 46.5% of value.

FOR

Corporates, employers and pension funds

Recruit where graduates are looking for work: a quarter of Morocco's tertiary-educated workforce was unemployed in 2022, and more than a fifth of Tunisia's in 2023.

For pension funds and insurers, listed student-housing REIT units with published asset-level data, as in Kenya, are a way to hold the asset class in local currency.

A DATA AGENDA

Seven figures Africa's student cities should publish

Most of the questions in the Student Bed Test can be answered in Nairobi and Pretoria and almost nowhere else. Many of the numbers are likely held by ministries, regulators, universities and operators, but they are not published.

Each of the seven figures opposite would let lenders and developers price student housing in a market they currently have to guess at.

How Heirstone works on student cities

We help governments, universities, developers and investors decide what to build for students and what it is worth: demand studies by campus and cohort, highest and best use and site selection, feasibility and business models (DCF, IRR, NPV and Monte Carlo testing), public-private structuring and benchmarking of the kind in this report.

Get in touch
info@heirstoneconsulting.com
heirstoneconsulting.com

1 **Enrolment that can be compared**
Nigeria's last UNESCO-comparable ratio is for 2011, Ethiopia's and Uganda's for 2014. The enrolment ratios behind the two largest cohorts in this report, Nigeria's and Ethiopia's, are more than a decade old.

2 **Applicants against places**
JAMB admissions against its 2.24 million candidates and KUCCPS placements against Kenya's 270,715 qualifiers, in a form comparable across countries.

3 **Public residence capacity and fees**
Public university residences by capacity and fee, such as Morocco's ONOUSC cités (about 30 in 16 cities) and Nigeria's federal hostels.

4 **Accredited private beds and rents**
By city and campus, as Respublica and Acorn already publish for their own portfolios.

5 **Bursary accommodation allowances**
The amount and payment timing of NSFAS allowances, which cap what the scheme pays for a South African private bed.

6 **Where students abroad go and what they spend**
Outbound flows by destination, and the foreign currency they absorb.

7 **Transactions and yields**
Outside Kenya's two REITs, we found no published student-housing valuation, yield or sale price in the 15 countries.

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

Notes

Definitions

GER: gross enrolment ratio, tertiary students of any age as a share of the five-year age group after secondary school. **18 to 24 cohort:** ages 18 and 19 plus the 20 to 24 group, both sexes, summed by Heirstone from World Bank projections. **Seats:** tertiary enrolment places. **Abroad / international students:** UNESCO's internationally mobile tertiary students. **Graduate unemployment:** unemployment among the labour force with advanced education (ILO-modelled). **PBSA:** purpose-built student accommodation. **ERV:** estimated rental value. **EPRA NIY:** net initial yield on the EPRA basis. **D-REIT / I-REIT:** development and income real estate investment trusts. **NSFAS:** South Africa's National Student Financial Aid Scheme. **SHIP:** Student Housing Infrastructure Programme. **Ahleya:** Egypt's national non-profit universities.

Method

Seats: school-age population implied as latest enrolment divided by GER, grown by the change in the 18 to 24 cohort from 2025 to 2035; seats needed are the target ratio times that population, less latest enrolment, floored at zero. Nigeria, Ethiopia and Uganda use five sevenths of the 18 to 24 cohort and their last UNESCO enrolment (2011, 2014), which overstates their needs. Types: see Exhibit 13. Currency: US$ at 2026 reference rates from the ExchangeRate-API open feed (KES 129.58, ZAR 16.66, NGN 1,331.28, EGP 52.25, GHS 11.62 per US$), not adjusted for past or future movements. Semester and term charges are divided by four months. Monthly minimum wages: South Africa hourly rate x 173.3 hours; Ghana daily rate x 26 days. Asking or "from" rents are not achieved rents. Where sources conflict we show both or use the more conservative figure.

Use of this report

This report is published for general information and uses public sources only. It is not investment, legal or valuation advice and should not be relied on as such. Country boundaries are from Natural Earth and imply no position on any territory. © Heirstone Consulting L.L.C-FZ, 2026. Images are illustrative.

Sources by chapter

1 SEATS

UNESCO Institute for Statistics data API: GER.5T8, 25053 (Feb 2026 release); World Bank WDI SE.TER.ENRR, SE.TER.ENRL; World Bank Population Estimates and Projections, source 40 (updated 1 Jul 2026); Kenya Ministry of Education KCSE results, as reported by Citizen Digital (2023, 2024, 2026); Channels Television and ICIR on 2026 UTME registrations (2026); JAMB 2026 admission policy; National Universities Commission, 2019 Statistical Digest.

2 MOBILITY AND PRIVATE SUPPLY

UNESCO UIS OE.5T8.40510 and 26637; NUC homepage statistics and private universities list (2026); Ghana Tertiary Education Commission; Ahram Online and Egypt's Ministry of Higher Education, via Assiut University (university numbers, 2025); STADIO; ADvTECH interim results 2026; Honoris United Universities; AUC tuition and residence rates; Universities of Canada in Egypt; Global Academic Foundation; European Universities in Egypt; University of East London (2024); The Knowledge Hub; AUN fees; Ashesi; CMU-Africa; ALU; UIR; Les Inspirations ÉCO (UIR, 2024); CCME (UIR, 2010); Egypt Today (Galala University, 2019); OpenStreetMap via Mapcarta (map positions).

3 BENCHMARK

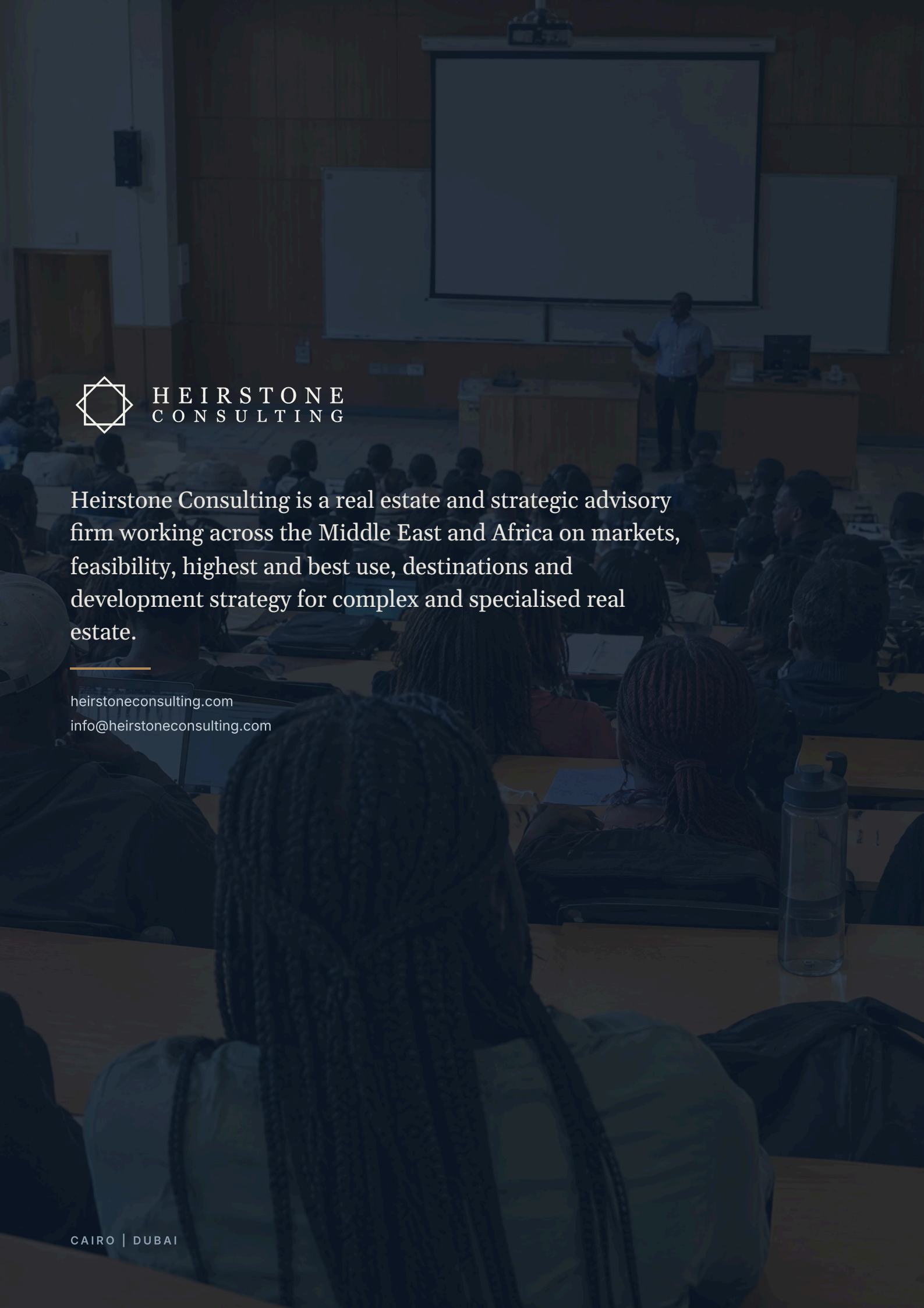
As above, plus World Bank WDI SL.UEM.ADVN.ZS (ILO-modelled unemployment among the labour force with advanced education); NSFAS, The DHET Bursary Scheme (2026).

4 BED ECONOMICS

Acorn Student Accommodation I-REIT and D-REIT 2025 annual reports (incl. occupancy by property); Acorn Holdings; Respublica 2027 rates table, residence pages, FAQs and media release (24 Oct 2025); CampusKey; DBSA, Student Housing Infrastructure Programme; WageIndicator (Kenya, Ghana); EWN (South Africa minimum wage, 2026); Channels Television (Nigeria minimum wage, 2024); Cairo Governorate (National Wages Council decision, 2025); ExchangeRate-API open feed (2026).

5 TO 7 TEST, REGIONS, RECOMMENDATIONS

Heirstone analysis of the sources above; ONOUSC, Réseaux des cités universitaires.



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heirstoneconsulting.com
info@heirstoneconsulting.com

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